ALCOHOL

Know the risks. Recognise dependence. Find support.

ALCOHOL IS A DRUG

Alcohol affects the brain, judgement, coordination and mood. It can cause dependence. Drinking problems can affect anyone, regardless of age, background or family circumstances.

HOW DOES ALCOHOL AFFECT YOU?

Alcohol slows reactions and reduces inhibition. Larger amounts increase the risk of accidents, injuries, vomiting, alcohol poisoning, blackouts and unsafe decisions.

LONGER-TERM HEALTH RISKS

Regular drinking increases the risk of liver disease, high blood pressure, heart problems, stroke and several cancers. It can also worsen anxiety, depression and sleep.

DEPENDENCE & CRAVINGS

Needing more alcohol for the same effect, drinking to cope, losing control or needing a morning drink can indicate dependence. Shame can make seeking help harder.

IMPACT ON FAMILIES

Problem drinking can affect finances, relationships, parenting and emotional safety. Children and partners may suffer even when drinking is hidden.

LOWER-RISK ADVICE

There is no completely safe drinking level. UK guidance advises no more than 14 units a week, spread over three or more days, if you drink.

IMPORTANT: DO NOT STOP SUDDENLY IF DEPENDENT

If you shake, sweat, vomit or feel unwell when alcohol wears off, ask a GP or alcohol service for medical advice before stopping. Sudden withdrawal can cause seizures or dangerous confusion and may need supervised treatment.

THE KEY MESSAGE

Alcohol dependence is a health issue, not a moral failure. Effective treatment and recovery support are available.

RECOGNISE THE SIGNS. GET HELP EARLY.

Practical information for individuals, parents and families.

WHEN TO SEEK URGENT HELP

Call 999 if someone is unconscious, has slow or irregular breathing, has a seizure, or develops severe withdrawal symptoms such as hallucinations or confusion. Stay with them and tell paramedics what happened.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Talk to your GP or a local alcohol service if you are worried about your drinking. Families: speak privately, listen without accusations and seek support for yourselves too. If you are physically dependent, get medical advice before cutting down or stopping.

UK LAW | ENGLAND & WALES

Alcohol is legal for adults, but its sale and use are regulated. These rules are different from controlled-drug possession offences.

POSSESSION	Adults may generally possess alcohol lawfully; ordinary possession is not a drug offence.
SELLING / SUPPLY	Retail sales generally require authorisation. Selling alcohol to under-18s is illegal.
DRINK-DRIVING	Driving over the legal limit or while unfit: at least a 1-year ban, up to 6 months in prison and an unlimited fine.

Under-18s cannot buy alcohol; adults generally cannot buy it for them. Limited exceptions apply to 16- and 17-year-olds drinking beer, wine or cider with a meal and an adult.

FAMILIES, STIGMA & SUPPORT

In some South Asian families, fear of shame or judgement can lead to secret drinking and delayed treatment. A calm conversation and a confidential referral are more helpful than blame or threats.

LOCAL SUPPORT IN ROCHDALE

TURNING POINT / ROAR
Adults - drug and alcohol recovery — **0300 555 0234**

EARLY BREAK
Young people and families — **0161 723 3880**

Seeking help is a sign of strength, not shame.

Sources: NHS Alcohol-use disorder and drinking risks; GOV.UK drink-driving penalties and alcohol/young people law; NHS local service directory (2026).